

FREE 8-WEEK TRAINING PROGRAM

FOUNDATIONS STRENGTH

Not a workout of the day. Eight weeks of full-body progressive overload training built to actually build muscle and drop fat — with a simple, honest way to know it's working.

ALEX WATSON — BSc HONS · L3 PT · L1 S&C

WHY RANDOM WORKOUTS DON'T WORK

Most free strength plans are a list of exercises with no logic connecting one week to the next — a "workout" rather than a program. You do it, you feel sore, and eight weeks later you look almost exactly like you did on day one, because nothing was ever asked to get harder.

This program is built around one principle: **progressive overload or it isn't training, it's just exercise**. Every week either the load, the reps, or the volume goes up on your main lifts — small, planned, deliberate increases — because that's the actual mechanism that builds muscle and changes your body composition. Nothing else does.

Who this is for: you want to build muscle and/or lose fat and you're after a structured plan rather than a random mix of exercises — whether you're new to structured lifting or you've drifted away from a real program.

Structure: 3 full-body sessions per week, 45-60 minutes each. Three phases:

PHASE	WEEKS	FOCUS
Base	1-3	Technique, moderate volume, establish your working loads
Build	4-6	Increased load and intensity on main lifts, added accessory volume
Peak	7-8	Heavier top sets, then a test week to measure what changed

Loading: effort is prescribed by RPE (Rate of Perceived Exertion, 1-10 — how many reps you had left in the tank). RPE 7 means you could do 3 more reps if pushed; RPE 9 means maybe 1 more. Pick a load each session that matches the target RPE for the prescribed reps, and write it down — you need last week's number to know if this week is actually progress.

Equipment: a standard gym setup — barbell, dumbbells, a bench, a pull-up bar or lat pulldown, and a cable station if available. Substitutions are noted where a home-gym alternative exists.

SESSION 1 – FULL BODY A

EXERCISE	SETS X REPS	TARGET RPE
Barbell back squat (or goblet squat)	3 x 8	6-7
Flat bench press (or push-up)	3 x 10	6-7
Bent-over row	3 x 10	6-7
Plank	3 x 30s	-

SESSION 2 – FULL BODY B

EXERCISE	SETS X REPS	TARGET RPE
Romanian deadlift	3 x 8	6-7
Seated overhead press (or DB press)	3 x 10	6-7
Lat pulldown (or pull-up, assisted if needed)	3 x 10	6-7
Farmers carry	3 x 30m	-

SESSION 3 – FULL BODY C

EXERCISE	SETS X REPS	TARGET RPE
Walking lunge	3 x 12 (6/leg)	6-7
Incline dumbbell press	3 x 10	6-7
Seated cable row	3 x 10	6-7
Cable or banded pallof press	3 x 10 per side	-

Write down the load you use for every exercise this week – it's your baseline for progression from here.

WEEK 2

BASE PHASE

SESSION 1 – FULL BODY A

EXERCISE	SETS X REPS	TARGET RPE
Barbell back squat	3 x 8	7
Flat bench press	3 x 10	7
Bent-over row	3 x 10	7
Plank	3 x 35s	-

SESSION 2 – FULL BODY B

EXERCISE	SETS X REPS	TARGET RPE
Romanian deadlift	3 x 9	7
Seated overhead press	3 x 10	7
Lat pulldown	3 x 11	7
Farmers carry	3 x 35m	-

SESSION 3 – FULL BODY C

EXERCISE	SETS X REPS	TARGET RPE
Walking lunge	3 x 14	7
Incline dumbbell press	3 x 11	7
Seated cable row	3 x 11	7
Pallof press	3 x 12 per side	-

Progression rule this week: same load as Week 1, one more rep per set where listed, one higher RPE. That's the whole game.

WEEK 3

BASE PHASE — CHECK-IN

SESSION 1 — FULL BODY A

EXERCISE	SETS X REPS	TARGET RPE
Barbell back squat	4 x 8	7
Flat bench press	4 x 10	7
Bent-over row	3 x 10	7
Plank	3 x 40s	-

SESSION 2 — FULL BODY B

EXERCISE	SETS X REPS	TARGET RPE
Romanian deadlift	4 x 8	7
Seated overhead press	4 x 10	7
Lat pulldown	3 x 12	7
Farmers carry	3 x 40m	-

SESSION 3 — FULL BODY C

EXERCISE	SETS X REPS	TARGET RPE
Walking lunge	3 x 16	7
Incline dumbbell press	4 x 10	7
Seated cable row	3 x 12	7
Pallof press	3 x 12 per side	-

Check-in point: compare loads to Week 1. You should be lifting more weight, or the same weight for more reps, on every main lift. If not, that's useful information — not a failure.

WEEK 4

BUILD PHASE

SESSION 1 – FULL BODY A

EXERCISE	SETS X REPS	TARGET RPE
Barbell back squat	4 x 6	7-8
Flat bench press	4 x 8	7-8
Bent-over row	4 x 8	7-8
Weighted plank	3 x 40s	-

SESSION 2 – FULL BODY B

EXERCISE	SETS X REPS	TARGET RPE
Romanian deadlift	4 x 6	7-8
Seated overhead press	4 x 8	7-8
Lat pulldown / pull-up	4 x 8	7-8
Farmers carry, heavier	4 x 35m	-

SESSION 3 – FULL BODY C

EXERCISE	SETS X REPS	TARGET RPE
Bulgarian split squat	3 x 10 per side	7-8
Incline dumbbell press	4 x 10	7-8
Seated cable row	4 x 10	7-8
Pallof press	3 x 12 per side	-

Reps drop, load goes up on the main lifts (squat, bench, row, RDL, press). This is the shift from "building capacity" to "building strength and size."

WEEK 5

BUILD PHASE

SESSION 1 – FULL BODY A

EXERCISE	SETS X REPS	TARGET RPE
Barbell back squat	4 x 6	8
Flat bench press	4 x 8	8
Bent-over row	4 x 8	8
Weighted plank	3 x 45s	-

SESSION 2 – FULL BODY B

EXERCISE	SETS X REPS	TARGET RPE
Romanian deadlift	4 x 6	8
Seated overhead press	4 x 8	8
Lat pulldown / pull-up	4 x 9	8
Farmers carry, heavier	4 x 40m	-

SESSION 3 – FULL BODY C

EXERCISE	SETS X REPS	TARGET RPE
Bulgarian split squat	3 x 12 per side	8
Incline dumbbell press	4 x 11	8
Seated cable row	4 x 11	8
Pallof press	3 x 14 per side	-

WEEK 6

BUILD PHASE – CHECK-IN

SESSION 1 – FULL BODY A

EXERCISE	SETS X REPS	TARGET RPE
Barbell back squat	4 x 5	8
Flat bench press	4 x 7	8
Bent-over row	4 x 8	8
Weighted plank	3 x 45s	-

SESSION 2 – FULL BODY B

EXERCISE	SETS X REPS	TARGET RPE
Romanian deadlift	4 x 5	8
Seated overhead press	4 x 7	8
Lat pulldown / pull-up	4 x 9	8
Farmers carry	4 x 40m	-

SESSION 3 – FULL BODY C

EXERCISE	SETS X REPS	TARGET RPE
Bulgarian split squat	3 x 12 per side	8
Incline dumbbell press	4 x 10	8
Seated cable row	4 x 11	8
Pallof press	3 x 14 per side	-

Second check-in: compare against Week 4. Loads and/or reps should be climbing across all three main lift patterns (squat, hinge, press).

WEEK 7

PEAK PHASE

SESSION 1 – FULL BODY A

EXERCISE	SETS X REPS	TARGET RPE
Barbell back squat	5 x 5	8-9
Flat bench press	5 x 5	8-9
Bent-over row	4 x 8	8
Plank	3 x 45s	-

SESSION 2 – FULL BODY B

EXERCISE	SETS X REPS	TARGET RPE
Romanian deadlift	5 x 5	8-9
Seated overhead press	5 x 5	8-9
Lat pulldown / pull-up	4 x 8	8
Farmers carry	3 x 40m	-

SESSION 3 – FULL BODY C (LIGHTER, AHEAD OF TEST WEEK)

EXERCISE	SETS X REPS	TARGET RPE
Bulgarian split squat	2 x 10 per side	6-7
Incline dumbbell press	3 x 10	6-7
Seated cable row	3 x 10	6-7

Session 3 volume is deliberately reduced – you're heading into a test week and don't need to arrive fatigued.

WEEK 8

PEAK PHASE — TEST WEEK

SESSION 1 — FULL BODY A TEST

EXERCISE	PROTOCOL
Barbell back squat	Work up to a heavy 5-rep set (RPE 9)
Flat bench press	Work up to a heavy 5-rep set (RPE 9)
Bent-over row	3 x 8 @ RPE 7

SESSION 2 — FULL BODY B TEST

EXERCISE	PROTOCOL
Romanian deadlift	Work up to a heavy 5-rep set (RPE 9)
Seated overhead press	Work up to a heavy 5-rep set (RPE 9)
Lat pulldown / pull-up	3 x 8 @ RPE 7

SESSION 3 — EASY FULL BODY

EXERCISE	SETS X REPS	TARGET RPE
Walking lunge	2 x 12	6
Incline dumbbell press	2 x 12	6
Seated cable row	2 x 12	6

Compare your Week 8 5-rep test loads against your Week 1 baselines on squat, bench, RDL, and overhead press. That difference is eight weeks of real, measurable progress — and it tells you exactly where the next block should push hardest.

LIFT	WEEK 1 (3X8 LOAD)	WEEK 8 (5RM)	CHANGE
Back squat			
Bench press			
Romanian deadlift			
Overhead press			

WHAT NOW

YOU'VE DONE THE STRUCTURED VERSION. NOW MAKE IT YOURS.

This program builds real strength and muscle in general terms.

Coaching gets you a plan built around your actual lifts, your actual schedule, and your actual weak points — adjusted week to week instead of fixed on a page.

BOOK A FREE CONSULT →

alexwatson444@gmail.com · @alexwatsoncoach · 07397 882264